

Workplace Readiness Skills — Self-Representation

Standard 1.1.4 | Personal Qualities & People Skills

Name: _____ Period: _____ Date: _____

■ STANDARDS CONNECTION

Studies show that employers form a lasting first impression within 7 seconds of meeting a candidate — before a single word is spoken. How you dress, carry yourself, and communicate signals professionalism before your skills ever do.

What Is Self-Representation?

Self-representation is how you present yourself to the professional world — through your appearance, language, body language, and behavior. It is not about conforming to one style; it is about understanding that your presentation sends a message, and being intentional about what that message says.

Dimension	What it includes
Professional appearance	Clothing appropriate to the workplace, clean and well-maintained.
Language	Avoiding slang, using proper grammar, adjusting tone to the audience.
Body language	Eye contact, posture, handshake, facial expression.
Digital presence	What your social media, email address, and online profiles say about you.
Consistency	Presenting the same professional standard every day, not just on good days.

Part 1 — Professional or Unprofessional? You Decide.

For each behavior below, **circle PROFESSIONAL or UNPROFESSIONAL**. Then circle the **two items you think are most debatable** — where reasonable people might disagree — and explain your reasoning below.

Behavior	Your Call
Wearing a hoodie and jeans to a job interview at a bank.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Using "gonna" and "wanna" in a client email.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Making direct eye contact and offering a firm handshake.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Checking your phone while a supervisor is speaking to you.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Wearing scrubs and closed-toed shoes on your first day at a clinic.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL

Behavior	Your Call
Having a professional profile photo on LinkedIn.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Using a nickname email (partyanimal22@gmail.com) on a job application.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL
Showing up to a work luncheon in formal interview-style attire.	PROFESSIONAL / UNPROFESSIONAL

The two most debatable items and why:

Part 2 — Scenario Questions

Respond in **complete sentences**. Support your position with specific reasoning.

SCENARIO 1

Nicole wears outfits to work that her manager has told her twice are inappropriate for the office. Nicole disagrees — she thinks her style is fine and believes the dress code is outdated and unfair.

Who is right here, and why? Does it matter whether Nicole personally agrees with the dress code? At what point does personal style become a professional liability? Defend your position in at least 3 sentences.

SCENARIO 2

Two candidates apply for the same job. Candidate A has slightly stronger technical skills but arrives to the interview in casual clothing and uses informal language. Candidate B has slightly weaker technical skills but arrives dressed professionally and communicates formally and clearly.

Which candidate do you think gets the job, and why? Is it fair that presentation can outweigh technical skill? What does this tell you about how the professional world works?

SCENARIO 3

A hiring manager Googles a job applicant and finds public social media posts with profanity, party photos, and complaints about a previous employer. The applicant's resume and interview were excellent.

Should the hiring manager factor in the social media content? Is it fair to judge someone's professional fitness by their personal social media? Where should the line be? Give your honest opinion.

SCENARIO 4

A student says: "I should be judged on my skills and work quality, not on what I wear or how I talk. Judging people on appearance is shallow."

Do you agree or disagree? Is there a difference between appearance-based discrimination and professional presentation standards? How would you explain self-representation to someone who holds this view?

■ PEER COMPARISON

Find a classmate and compare your answer to Scenario 3. Write **one thing that was different** about how you each responded — and explain which response you think is stronger and why.

■ RESEARCH EXTENSION (if time allows)

Search "professional dress code by industry" and find one career field relevant to your program. Write 3 sentences describing what professional dress looks like in that field and one thing that would be unprofessional. **OR** — describe a real situation where someone's appearance or language made a strong professional impression on you — positive or negative.

✂ EXIT TICKET — detach and hand to your teacher on the way out

Exit Ticket — Standard 1.1.4: Self-Representation

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REFLECT & RESPOND

Identify one specific change you could make to how you present yourself professionally — in appearance, language, body language, or online presence. Explain why that change matters in your career pathway and what the cost could be if you do not make it. Write at least 3 complete sentences.

This standard is assessed on the Nevada WRS exam. Your honest, thoughtful reflection here helps you think like a professional — which is exactly what the exam tests.